

Building a Healthy Plate

A healthy plate is a simple way to build balanced meals without counting every bite. Use it at home, at the hawker centre, or when packing lunch for work.

The quarter-quarter-half idea

Picture your plate in three parts: half for vegetables and fruit, one quarter for wholegrains or other staple foods, and one quarter for protein foods. This pattern helps you get fibre, steady energy, and enough fullness to last until the next meal.

Plate part	Choose more often	Easy local examples
Half	Vegetables and fruit	Stir-fried greens, salad, sliced fruit
Quarter	Wholegrains or staples	Brown rice, wholemeal bread, oats
Quarter	Protein foods	Fish, chicken, tofu, eggs, beans

The plate is a guide, not a strict rule. If your meal comes in a bowl, aim for the same balance: more vegetables, a sensible amount of noodles or rice, and a protein item.

Hawker meals that fit the plate

Small changes can improve a familiar meal. For economy rice, choose two vegetable dishes, one protein dish, and ask for less gravy. For chicken rice, ask for more cucumber, add a vegetable side if available, and keep the rice portion modest. For fish soup, add vegetables and choose clear soup more often. For thosai or chapati, pair it with vegetables and a protein item, and go easy on rich sauces.

When a stall offers brown rice or wholegrain noodles, try them. If the taste is new to you, start with a mixed portion, such as half white rice and half brown rice.

At home: make the healthy choice easy

Keep a few ready-to-use basics at home: frozen vegetables, eggs, tofu, canned beans, oats, and fruit. A quick meal can be brown rice with vegetables and fish, or wholemeal toast with egg and tomatoes. Batch-cook a staple or protein once or twice a week so meals are easier after work.

For flavour, use herbs, garlic, ginger, chilli, lime, vinegar, and spices. Taste the food before adding extra sauce or salt. Serve sauces at the side so each person can use less.

Drinks and snacks

Water is the everyday drink. If you take kopi, teh, or packaged drinks, choose less sweet options more often. For snacks, fruit, plain yoghurt, unsalted nuts, or wholegrain crackers are usually more filling than sweet drinks and pastries.

Key points

- Aim for half vegetables and fruit, one quarter wholegrains or staples, and one quarter protein foods.
- Choose wholegrain options when available, starting with mixed portions if needed.
- At hawker centres, ask for less gravy and add vegetables.
- Keep healthier basics at home so balanced meals are convenient.
- Choose water or less sweet drinks most of the time.

When to talk to a health professional

Speak to a doctor or dietitian if you have a medical condition, have been told to follow a special diet, are losing weight without trying, or feel unsure about what foods are suitable for you.

This guide is sample content written for the LiveWell Coach workshop. It is general information, not medical advice. If you have symptoms or a health condition, speak to a doctor.